

- Customers were involved from the inception of each feature concept.

It's important to understand that the old approach did not lack customer feedback or customer involvement in the planning process. In the true spirit of *genchi gembutsu*, Intuit product managers (PMs) would do “follow-me-homes” with customers to identify problems to solve in the next release. However, the PMs were responsible for all the customer research. They would bring it back to the team and say, “This is the problem we want to solve, and here are ideas for how we could solve it.”

Changing to a cross-functional way of working was not smooth sailing. Some team members were skeptical. For example, some product managers felt that it was a waste of time for engineers to spend time in front of customers. The PMs thought that their job was to figure out the customer issue and define what needed to be built. Thus, the reaction of some PMs to the change was: “What’s my job? What am I supposed to be doing?” Similarly, some on the engineering side just wanted to be told what to do; they didn’t want to talk to customers. As is typically the case in large-batch development, both groups had been willing to sacrifice the team’s ability to learn in order to work more “efficiently.”

Communication was critical for this change process to succeed. All the team leaders were open about the change they were driving and why they were driving it. Much of the skepticism they faced was based on the fact that they did not have concrete examples of where this had worked in the past; it was an entirely new process for Intuit. They had to explain clearly why the old process didn’t work and why the annual release “train” was not setting them up for success. Throughout the change they communicated the process outcomes they were shooting for: earlier customer feedback and a faster development cycle that was decoupled from the annual release time line. They repeatedly emphasized that the new approach was how startup competitors were working and iterating. They had to follow suit or risk becoming irrelevant.